Specification of the controlled designation of origin "PESSAC-LÉOGNAN"

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CHAPTER I

I. – Name of the designation

Only wines meeting the specific provisions set out below may claim the controlled designation of origin "Pessac-Léognan", initially recognised by the decree of 9 September 1987.

II. – Geographical denominations and complementary terms

No specific provision.

III. – Colour and types of product

The controlled designation of origin "Pessac-Léognan" is reserved for still white and red wines.

IV. – Areas and zones in which the various operations are carried out

1° – Geographical area

The harvesting of the grapes, the vinification, the elaboration, the ageing and the packaging of the wines are carried out within the territory of the following communes of the Gironde department, on the basis of the official geographic code dated 26 February 2020: Cadaujac, Canéjan, Gradignan, Léognan, Martillac, Mérignac, Pessac, Saint-Médard-d'Eyrans, Talence and Villenave-d'Ornon.

2° – Delimited parcel area

The wines come exclusively from vines situated within the delimited parcel production area as approved by the National Institute of Origin and Quality at the sessions of the competent national committee of 3 and 4 November 1994, of 10 September 1997, of 8 and 9 March 2006, of 10 February 2011 and of 11 February 2021.

The National Institute of Origin and Quality lodges with the town halls of the communes referred to in 1° the graphic documents establishing the parcel boundaries of the production area thus approved.

V. – Grape varieties

a) – The white wines come from the following varieties: muscadelle B, sauvignon B, sauvignon gris G, sémillon B.

b) – The red wines come from the following varieties: cabernet franc N, cabernet-sauvignon N, carmenère N, cot N (or malbec), merlot N and petit verdot N.

VI. – Management of the vineyard

1° – Training methods

a) – Planting density.
The vines present a minimum planting density of 6,500 plants per hectare. The spacing between rows may not be greater than 1.60 metre and the distance between plants within the same row may not be less than 0.80 metre.

b) – Pruning rules.
The vines are pruned at the latest by the spread-leaves stage (Lorenz stage 9), with a maximum of 12 free eyes (buds) per plant and according to the following provisions:

- so-called spur (cots or coursons) and cane (astes or long-wood) pruning: the long wood bears at most 7 free eyes for the varieties cabernet-sauvignon N, cot N, merlot N, muscadelle B, petit verdot N and sémillon B, and 8 free eyes for the varieties cabernet franc N, carmenère N and sauvignon B. The return spurs number at most 2, pruned to one free eye;

- spur pruning to 2 cordons, or four-arm fan training.

c) – Trellising rules and foliage height.
The height of the trellised foliage must be at least equal to 0.6 times the spacing between rows, the height of trellised foliage being measured at its lower limit at 0.10 metre below the bending wire and at its upper limit at the topping height.

d) – Average maximum load per parcel.

- The average maximum load per parcel is fixed at 8,500 kilograms per hectare for the black varieties and 9,000 kilograms per hectare for the white and grey varieties; this load corresponds to a maximum number of 12 bunches per plant.

- Where irrigation is authorised, in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-5 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, the average maximum load per parcel of the irrigated parcels is fixed at 7,000 kilograms per hectare.

e) – Threshold for missing vines.
The percentage of dead or missing vine plants, referred to in Article D. 645-4 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, is fixed at 20 %. Dead plants must be removed from the parcels; any storage of these dead plants on the parcels is prohibited.

f) – Cultivation condition of the vine.
The parcels are managed so as to ensure a good overall cultivation condition of the vine, in particular its sanitary condition, the upkeep of its soil and the sanitary condition of the harvest. In particular, no parcel may be left abandoned.

2° – Other cultivation practices

In order to preserve the characteristics of the soils that constitute a fundamental element of the terroir, any substantial modification of the morphology of the relief and of the natural pedological sequence of the parcels intended for the production of the controlled designation of origin is prohibited, with the exception of classic deep-ploughing works.

Chemical weeding of the headlands is prohibited. Total chemical weeding of the parcels is prohibited. On all the inter-rows, the control of the vegetation, sown or spontaneous, is ensured by mechanical or physical means. Every operator calculates and records its treatment frequency index (IFT).

3° – Irrigation

Irrigation during the vine's growing period may be authorised, in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-5 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, only in the event of persistent drought and when this disturbs the good physiological development of the vine and the good ripeness of the grape.

VII. – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes

1° – Harvest

The wines come from grapes harvested at proper ripeness and presenting a good sanitary condition.

2° – Ripeness of the grapes

a) – Sugar content of the grapes. Grapes with a sugar content of less than the following may not be considered to be at proper ripeness:

- 189 grams per litre of must for the merlot N variety and 180 grams per litre of must for the other black varieties;

- 187 grams per litre of must for the sauvignon B and sauvignon gris G varieties and 178 grams per litre of must for the other white varieties.

b) – Minimum natural alcoholic strength by volume. The wines present a minimum natural alcoholic strength by volume of 11 %.

VIII. – Yields. – Entry into production

1° – Yield

The yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 54 hectolitres per hectare.

2° – Limit yield

The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 60 hectolitres per hectare.

3° – Entry into production of young vines

The benefit of the controlled designation of origin may be granted to wines coming from:

- parcels of young vines only from the 2nd year following that in the course of which planting was carried out in place before 31 July;

- parcels of young vines only from the 1st year following that in the course of which grafting in place was carried out before 31 July;

- parcels of vines that have been top-grafted, at the earliest in the 1st year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, and once the parcels no longer contain any varieties other than those permitted for the appellation. By way of derogation, in the year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, the varieties permitted for the appellation may represent only 80 % of the grape varieties of each parcel concerned.

IX. – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage

1° – General provisions

The wines are vinified in accordance with local, fair and constant usages.

a) – Malolactic fermentation. At the packaging stage, every lot of red wine presents a malic acid content less than or equal to 0.30 gram per litre.

b) – Analytical standards. At the packaging stage, the wines present:

- a content of fermentable sugars (glucose + fructose) less than or equal to 4 grams per litre for the white wines and 2 grams per litre for the red wines;

- a volatile acidity content less than or equal to 16.33 milliequivalents per litre, i.e. 0.80 gram per litre expressed as H2SO4 or 0.98 gram per litre expressed as acetic acid.

c) – Oenological practices and physical treatments.

- Subtractive enrichment techniques (SET) are authorised for the red wines within the limit of a concentration rate of 15 %;

- After enrichment, the white wines do not exceed a total alcoholic strength by volume of 13 %.

- After enrichment, the red wines do not exceed a total alcoholic strength by volume of 13.5 %.

d) – Prohibited equipment.

- The use of the foulo-benne (self-emptying skip fitted with a so-called centrifugal paddle pump) is prohibited.

- The use of the continuous-type press fitted with an endless screw of a diameter less than 400 millimetres is prohibited.

e) – Overall vinification vat capacity.

- For the red wines, the overall capacity of the vinification vats is at least 1.5 times the average production of the vinification site over 3 years;

- For the white wines, a barrel cellar representing a volume equivalent to the average production of the vinification site over 3 years is recommended. In the absence of a barrel cellar, the overall capacity of the vinification vats is at least 1.5 times the average production of the vinification site over 3 years.

f) – Good overall condition of upkeep of the cellar (floor and walls) and of the equipment (hygiene). The cellar (floors and walls) and the vinification equipment present a good general condition of upkeep.

2° – Provisions by type of product

a) – Temperature control. The vinification cellars are equipped with a temperature-control device, at least for cooling. Waste-water runoff devices on the vats are strictly prohibited.

b) – Ageing.

- The red wines are aged at least until 15 September of the year following that of the harvest.

- The white wines are aged at least until 15 March of the year following that of the harvest.

c) – Barrel cellar. The operator has a place suitable for ageing in barrels for a volume of at least one third of the average red-wine production, calculated over the last 3 harvests.

3° – Provisions relating to packaging

a) – In order to preserve the essential characteristics and the authenticity of the wines, these are packaged either in glass bottles or in hermetic, vacuum-sealed containers of 5 litres maximum, at the premises of the operator harvesting the grapes and vinifying these wines.

b) – For each packaged lot, the operator keeps available for the defence and management body and for the approved control body:

- the information appearing in the register of handling operations referred to in Article D. 645-18 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code;

- an analysis carried out before or after packaging.

The analysis reports must be kept for a period of 6 months from the date of packaging.

4° – Provisions relating to storage

The operator demonstrates a specific place for the storage of the packaged products.

5° – Provisions relating to placing on the market for the consumer

At the end of the ageing period:

- the white wines are placed on the market for the consumer from 30 March of the year following that of the harvest.

- the red wines are placed on the market for the consumer from 1 October of the year following that of the harvest.

X. – Link with the geographical area

1° – Information on the geographical area

a) – Description of the natural factors contributing to the link

The geographical area extends over the northern part of the controlled designation of origin “Graves”, bordering to the west and south the city of Bordeaux, on the left bank of the Garonne. It covers the territory of 10 communes of the Gironde department.

The characteristic soils are the witnesses of the ancient courses of the Garonne, which fluctuated at the end of the Tertiary and during the Quaternary, according to the successive meltings of the Pyrenean glaciers. Considerable quantities of materials were then carried and deposited, according to the power of the currents and the density of the sediments, on ancient sea beds made up of limestones and shelly falun. Erosion then shaped the soils represented by:

- soils developed on gravels or pebbles rolled by the waters, of a thickness that can reach three metres and more,

- soils developed on calcareous clays, sands and falun, the whole resting on a base of fissured and permeable limestone rock.

This pedological complexity makes the richness of the natural environment of the controlled designation of origin.

Set in a slightly undulating relief, the gravel deposits form knolls particularly well drawn in the landscape. The gentle slopes ensure a remarkable natural drainage facilitated by an important hydrographic network of small watercourses, tributaries of the Garonne.

The general climate is very representative of that of the Gironde, temperate and favourable to the vine by its mildness and its regular humidity. It benefits from the thermoregulating protection of the forest of the Landes girondines, to the south, and of the Atlantic Ocean, to the west.

The geographical area has the particularity of being situated on the periphery of the city of Bordeaux, and sometimes enclaved within the conurbation. A few “crus”, among the most renowned, thus form havens of greenery in the very heart of the dense urbanisation, resistant to property speculation. The vine parcels struggle against suburban smothering thanks to the will of people to safeguard this exceptional heritage.

b) – Description of the human factors contributing to the link

The “Graves” region comprises, around the city of Bordeaux, a very original territory called in the Middle Ages “Las Grabas de Bourdeus” (“The Graves of Bordeaux”). They are, 2000 years ago, around the port, the cradle of a vineyard whose prestigious name is now known throughout the world.

In 1152, the marriage of Eleanor of Aquitaine with the king of England brings serious reasons to prosper. Reasons all the more serious as they would soon rely on the granting to the “Banlieue” of Bordeaux of the famous “Privilège” which prohibits any competition as long as a single barrel of “town wine” remains to be sold.

The golden age opens, in the 14th century, on an English craze for “Claret”. The wine estates then develop and the privileged “Banlieue Prévôtale” is extended to the present limits of the geographical area.

From 1531 to 1551, Jean de Pontac builds, parcel by parcel, at the locality “Haut-Brion”, a true wine-growing enterprise that perfectly prefigures the great Bordeaux “Château” and gives birth to the notion of “Grand Cru”. During the first half of the 19th century, most of the estates adorn themselves with the title of “Château”.

Much later, through a slow process of degradation, thousands of hectares are destroyed by the development of the city of Bordeaux and its immediately suburban communes. The vineyard of the “Graves” loses, in the geographical area of the future controlled designation of origin “Pessac-Léognan” alone, more than 3,000 hectares and several hundred “crus” between the beginning of the 20th century and the 1970s. At that date, it numbers no more than 550 hectares, of which 100 hectares condemned in the short term.

A group of dynamic and enterprising young wine-growers then launches into the reconquest and requests the hierarchisation of the controlled designation of origin “Graves”. The controlled designation of origin “Pessac-Léognan” is thus recognised by decree of 9 September 1987, in the image of the communal appellations of the “Médoc”, confirming the specificities of this geographical area, an integral part of the geographical area of the controlled designation of origin “Graves”, of which it was the original terroir.

The vineyard of “Pessac-Léognan”, with an area of 1,640 hectares in 2010, farmed by 61 producers, produces on average 70,000 hectolitres of which more than 80 % red wines. This balance of production between red wines and dry white wines is constant and testifies to a centuries-old regularity.

2° – Information on the quality and characteristics of the products

The wines are dry still wines, red or white.

The red wines come mainly from the cabernet-sauvignon N variety, an ancestral variety of the Bordeaux controlled designations of origin, perfectly suited to these gravelly soils to attain an optimal ripeness. This variety gives very colourful wines, of strong tannic structure, able to age for very many years. With time, its complex aromas with frequent notes of blackcurrant often evolve towards smoky, spicy, leather and prune aromas. The ageing is most often carried out in oak barrels, the tannins of the fruit merging with those of the wood to give roundness and volume on the palate. The cabernet-sauvignon N variety is often combined with the merlot N and cabernet franc N varieties, which bring suppleness and add to its elegance, and sometimes with the cot N (or malbec), petit verdot N and carmenère N varieties, old Bordeaux varieties that add to the complexity of the wines.

The dry white wines, coming mainly from the sauvignon B and sémillon B varieties, are generally, in their youth, of a rather pale straw-yellow colour. They are fruity, sappy and lively. Combined in various proportions with the sauvignon gris G or muscadelle B varieties, their perfume is complex. With the years, they turn gently golden and develop very fine aromas of a floral character that sometimes recall lime blossom and broom. In years of great ripeness, the white wines are fleshier, rounder and longer on the palate.

3° – Causal interactions

The original land of the great white wines and the great red wines of Bordeaux, “Pessac-Léognan” is the cradle of practices still in use in 2010.

The varieties, cultivated under an oceanic climate, required, from the 17th and 18th centuries, supporting stakes. The generalisation of trellising and of a sufficiently severe pruning method made it possible to ensure a good distribution of the harvest and a leaf surface sufficient for good photosynthesis and an optimal ripeness. Likewise, in order to avoid overloading the vine plants with fruit, a guarantee of ripeness and optimal concentration of the wines, the planting density is high.

The delimited parcel area for the harvesting of the grapes classifies the parcels characterised by a gravelly to sandy-gravelly soil, but also sometimes clay-limestone, and having a sufficient draining potential owing to their permeability or their relief. The parcels situated on modern alluvium, on sands or on impermeable subsoil have been excluded. Moreover, any substantial modification of the morphology of the relief and of the natural pedological sequence of the parcels intended for the production of the controlled designation of origin is prohibited.

These carefully delimited parcels allow the optimal expressions of the local varieties, selected over the course of history for their aptitudes for conservation and ageing, linked to the historic necessity of long-distance transport of these products. The red wines benefit from a long period of ageing, necessary for their refining and their better expression before being placed on the market for the consumer. The dry white wines express a great finesse on the sandier or clay-matrix soils, with floral, fruity notes that do not lack freshness.

The classification of all the “Crus Classés de Graves” (1959 classification) within the geographical area, that is 16 “Châteaux” or “Domaines”, representing about a third of the holdings, testifies to the historic renown of the wines of “Pessac-Léognan”. The most illustrious of them is “Château Haut-Brion”, “Premier Grand Cru” of the 1855 classification of the wines of Bordeaux.

Through its proximity to the port of Bordeaux, where a powerful trade established itself distributing these wines throughout the world, the controlled designation of origin “Pessac-Léognan” rapidly acquired a worldwide renown, benefiting from technical innovations, encouraging the dynamism of the holdings, thus allowing them to develop while respecting the centuries-old usages.

Among other particularities, the producers of “Pessac-Léognan” almost all practise the “sale en primeur” on the Bordeaux marketplace, a tradition characteristic of the great wines of Bordeaux. It takes place in the spring following the harvest, between the owners and the merchants through the intermediary of the Bordeaux brokers. After this transaction, the wine is, under the responsibility of the seller, kept and aged until its packaging. Reflecting these usages, by integrating into the production conditions the carrying out of the packaging at the premises of the operator harvesting the grapes and vinifying the grapes, the producers set themselves the objective of better safeguarding the quality and the specificity of the product

and consequently the reputation of the controlled designation of origin. The wines of "Pessac-Léognan" are marketed beyond the borders of the national territory and exported throughout the world and participate fully in the promotion of the image of the Bordeaux marketplace and of its trade, in the world.

XI. – Transitional measures

1° – Training methods

a) – Parcels of vines planted before 31 August 1990, with a planting density between 5,000 plants per hectare and 6,500 plants per hectare, continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until their grubbing-up or until the 2030 harvest included under the following conditions:

- the volume that may benefit from the right to the controlled designation of origin is established on the basis of the yield authorised for the controlled designation of origin, for the harvest considered, until the 2015 harvest included;

- the volume that may benefit from the right to the controlled designation of origin is established on the basis of the yield authorised for the controlled designation of origin, for the harvest considered, to which the coefficient of 0.90 is applied, until the 2018 harvest included;

- the volume that may benefit from the right to the controlled designation of origin is established on the basis of the yield authorised for the controlled designation of origin, for the harvest considered, to which the coefficient of 0.80 is applied, until the 2023 harvest included;

- the volume that may benefit from the right to the controlled designation of origin is established on the basis of the yield authorised for the controlled designation of origin, for the harvest considered, to which the coefficient of 0.70 is applied, until the 2027 harvest included;

- the volume that may benefit from the right to the controlled designation of origin is established on the basis of the yield authorised for the controlled designation of origin, for the harvest considered, to which the coefficient of 0.60 is applied, until the 2030 harvest included.

b) – Parcels of vines planted before 31 July 2009 not complying with the provisions relating to the spacing between rows and to the distance between plants within the same row laid down in the present specification, but complying with the minimum planting density of 6,500 plants per hectare, continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until their grubbing-up.

XII. – Rules of presentation and labelling

1° – General provisions

Wines for which, under the terms of the present specification, the controlled designation of origin "Pessac-Léognan" is claimed and which are presented under the said appellation may not be declared after the harvest, offered to the public, dispatched, put up for sale or sold unless, in the harvest declaration, in advertisements, on leaflets, labels, invoices and any containers whatsoever, the aforesaid controlled designation of origin is entered.

2° – Particular provisions

a) – The larger geographical unit "Vin de Graves" or "Grand Vin de Graves" or "Vin de Bordeaux" or "Grand Vin de Bordeaux" may appear on the labels, leaflets and any containers. The dimensions of the characters of this larger geographical unit are not greater, both in height and in width, than two thirds of those of the characters composing the name of the controlled designation of origin.

b) – The term "Cru Classé de Graves" may appear in replacement of the larger geographical unit "Vin de Graves" or "Grand Vin de Graves" in compliance with the same conditions of presentation and of character dimension.

CHAPTER II

I. – Declaration obligations

1. Claim declaration

The claim declaration must be sent to the defence and management body before 15 March of the year following the harvest year.

It indicates:

- the designation claimed;

- the volume of the wine;

- the EVV or SIRET number;

- the name and address of the applicant;

- the place of storage of the wine.

It is accompanied by:

- a copy of the harvest declaration;

- a cellar plan (place of vinification and storage) allowing in particular the number, designation and capacity of the containers to be identified.

2. Prior declaration of removals or packaging

Every operator wishing to package wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin declares, to the approved control body, any packaging operation at least five working days before the operation.

3. Fallback (repli) declaration

Every operator marketing a wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin under a more general appellation must declare it to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum period of one month after this fallback.

4. Downgrading declaration

Every operator carrying out a downgrading of wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin must declare it to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum period of one month after this downgrading.

5. Reworking of parcels

Before any addition of soil or amendment, any development or any works liable to modify the soil profile or the morphology of the relief, with the exception of classic deep-ploughing works, or any modification of the landscape, a declaration must be sent by the operator to the defence and management body at least two months before the start of the envisaged works. The defence and management body transmits, without delay, a copy of this declaration to the services of the National Institute of Origin and Quality.

II. – Keeping of registers

1. Tasting register

All the packaged lots must be the subject of an organoleptic examination before and after packaging in accordance with the arrangements provided for in the control or inspection plan, an examination whose results are recorded in a tasting register.

2. Vines under transitional measures

Every operator concerned by the transitional provisions set at XI of Chapter I must keep available for the officers in charge of the control the inventory of the parcels concerned and, in the event of grubbing-up and replanting, a copy of the declaration of completion of works.

CHAPTER III

I – Main points to be checked and evaluation methods

MAIN POINTS TO BE CHECKED	EVALUATION METHODS
A – STRUCTURAL RULES	
A1 – Belonging of the planted parcels to the delimited area	Documentary check and check in the field
A2 – Claimable production potential (grape varieties and proportion rules, monitoring of transitional measures, planting density and trellising, abandoned vines)	Documentary check and check in the field
A3 – Processing, ageing, packaging and storage facilities	
Place of vinification	Documentary check and on-site check
Minimum capacity of the vinification vat room	Documentary check and on-site check
Temperature control	On-site check
Ageing	Documentary check and on-site check
Traceability of packaging	Documentary check (register keeping) and on-site check
Justified storage place for packaged products	Documentary check and on-site check
B – RULES LINKED TO THE PRODUCTION CYCLE	
B1 – Management of the vineyard. — Pruning	Counting of the number of free eyes (buds) per plant and description of the pruning method
Trellising rules and foliage height	Check in the field
Average maximum load per parcel	Counting of bunches and estimation of the load
Cultivation condition of the vine	Check at the parcel. Criteria for analysis of the state of the vines: significant presence, in the parcel, of woody plants other than the vine; significant presence of cryptogamic diseases
B2 – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes. — Ripeness of the grapes	- Verification of the records (information sheet specifying the maturity-monitoring method and the fermentable-sugar contents) at the operators'; - by sampling of 200 berries on site and refractometric check
B3 – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage. — Oenological practices or treatments (enrichment)	Documentary check and on-site check
B4 – Harvest declaration and claim declaration. — Missing vines	Documentary check (up-to-date list) and check in the field
Authorised yield	Documentary check [check of declarations, yield increase for certain operators (monitoring of the authorisations granted by the INAO services after enquiry by the said services upon individual request of the operator)]
VSI, volumes harvested in excess of the authorised yield	Documentary check (monitoring of destruction certificates)
Claim declaration	Documentary check and on-site check (compliance with the arrangements and deadlines, consistency with the harvest declaration…). Control of the placing into circulation of the products
C – CHECKS ON THE PRODUCTS	
Packaged wines	Analytical and organoleptic examination

II – References concerning the control structure

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The control of compliance with the present specification is carried out on the basis of an approved control plan and by a third-party body offering guarantees of competence, impartiality and independence and having received delegation from the INAO.

The control plan sets out the self-checks carried out by the operators on their own activity and the internal checks carried out under the responsibility of the defence and management body. It indicates the external checks carried out by the third-party body as well as the analytical and organoleptic examinations. All the checks are carried out by sampling. Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory are the subject of a systematic analytical and organoleptic check.